

Unconscious and Conscious Human Mental Life

[Det ubevidste og det bevidste menneskelige Sjæleliv]

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Nyt dansk Maanedsskrift, ed. Vilhelm Møller, vol. 3 (October 1871–March
1872), pp. 42–57

Translated from the Danish

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1.

Among all the problems with which the psychology of our day is occupied with renewed interest, there is none that has a wider compass and a greater reach than the problem of the relation between our conscious and our unconscious mental life. The series of phenomena it touches reaches from the individual's first coming into being to its cessation, and the forms of life whose relation it demands be cleared up point back to the fundamental oppositions of existence itself and to the relation between them. What constantly, with irresistible power, leads cognition back to this problem is our spirit's inescapable need to find unity in ourselves and in existence, and not to come to rest in dividedness as the final word. It is this need that twice in one century, and in wholly opposite directions, has led to one-sided formulas for the unity of man and of existence: to the unity formula of materialism, which lets the spiritual in existence vanish into moving matter, and lets the conscious life in us become a result of the combination of the elements of matter; — and to the unity formula of spiritualism, which lets nature vanish into a spirit without nature, and lets the life of thought in us tear itself loose from its organic conditionedness. It is this need that, once again, after the impracticability [43] of the one-sided formulas has become evident, leads to a striving for a unity that does not misjudge the distinctive character of the oppositions, but would see that character proceed from, and be joined together again in, a higher, richer uniting principle. —

It was at the beginning of modern philosophy that the sharp, dualistic distinction between what the psychology of our time designates as unconscious and conscious *mental life*, and strives to lead back to unity, was established through a consequence drawn not from a comprehensive, unbiased experience but from metaphysical presuppositions. Spirit and matter, thought and extension, were determined as opposites that did not meet in common predicates, but only excluded one another. In man, to be sure, one had been compelled by the force of the facts to posit spirit and matter, soul and body, as joined and as acting upon one another; but the connection was expressly determined as incomprehensible, and only as a composition, not as a real coming together into unity. Everything that belongs to the soul was to fall under the determination of thought and consciousness; everything that belongs to the body, under that of extension and motion, from which thought and consciousness were excluded. The body was therefore, even if the soul was to have a "seat" in it — but as a foreign guest and by an incomprehensible

miracle — conceived only as a machine, as a “divine automaton”, and everything that takes place in it was to happen according to the laws of mechanism. In the animal, where no soul was recognized, because the animal was denied thought and consciousness, this relation was seen to stand out most clearly. The interaction that was posited in man between soul and body, even if only through an inconsistency, and which could nevertheless be realized only in the forms of mechanism, here fell away, and every impulse to an activity here issued from something bodily. One then stubbornly refused to conceive even those phenomena within the animal world that most of all recalled those of human consciousness as expressions of a psychic activity. Thus, when the mistreated animal expressed its pain by its cry, one boldly denied, trusting in the unshakable firmness of one’s presuppositions, that the cry was a sign of a sensation. The animal’s cry, it was [44] said, was like the tone of a string, a purely mechanical effect of the blow that struck it.

From this dualistic theory, which sets an insurmountable boundary between human life and the lower forms of life, and which would unite into unity, in the human being, what is absolutely opposed, and thus irreconcilable, and would let what is assigned to absolutely different spheres — which must therefore lack any possibility of contact — enter into a relation of interaction, cognition of the absurd consequences and of the insoluble difficulties to which it led was nevertheless bound soon to lead away; and a freer, more unbiased view of the phenomena of reality and a sharper testing of the concepts of the opposites were bound to lead to a widening of the theory’s determinations of spirit and nature, and thereby to pave the way for the cognition of the unity that joins them together in the whole of existence and in the forms of human life.

It was from spirit’s consciousness of itself as thinking that that dualistic theory had taken its point of departure when it sought a secure foothold for cognition; and as spirit, in order to find its own essential determination, distinguished itself from everything from which it could abstract, the bodily was separated from it as wholly foreign to it and as that which had no determination in common with it. Therefore thought, and what was made one with it, namely consciousness, was kept apart by an insurmountable chasm from spirit’s opposite; psychic life received only one form, the life of consciousness, and between this life of consciousness and what took place in the unconscious no unity could be thought. And yet consciousness points of necessity to an essential connection with the unconscious. In its concept there lies an essential relation to that which is other than the I, in which other the material too is comprised; but an essential relation, as a necessary relation, includes the essential connection; only by that connection is the necessity of the relation explained. And the life of consciousness has a becoming,

[45] and in becoming it proceeds from an unconscious living that is an abiding condition of the reality of consciousness. By the very concept that was meant to keep the spiritual apart from the bodily, there is thus a pointing to a unity in the human being of spirit and nature, of the conscious and the unconscious; and there is thereby a pointing to a fuller and richer determination of the opposites than the one that could be given them as abstractly separated. In order that the unity can be realized for thought, the essence of nature must not be determined by what expresses the real (the bodily) only, as it were, at its greatest distance from spirit, by passive extension; its concept must be formed not from its poorest forms but from the highest phenomena, in which it expresses its complete essence most richly and most clearly: from the organic, the living, in which the ideality of nature comes to light. And the concept of spirit must not be determined solely from the phenomena in which the connection with the natural ground has, as it were, become invisible, but from the whole circle of its forms, and therefore also from those that show the spiritual in its temporal development as borne and conditioned by a real organic ground, the conscious life of spirit in unity with an unconscious psychic life, through which its connection with nature becomes manifest. From both points of departure, from nature and from spirit, one will then arrive at the essential unity of the opposites, and only by the recognition of this essential unity will the facts be able to be understood in their completeness.

When the opposites in the human being are seen in unity, the concept of *life* becomes that which binds them together; it is at once that which expresses the essence of nature and that which forms the ground of the essence of spirit. We then see life as comprising the two forms, the organic and the psychic in the narrower sense, unconscious and conscious life; and as the human being is seen as a unity and the unity is determined from the standpoint of the highest form, the term *psychic* life, in the wider sense, is extended to life in *its entirety*, and *the soul* is seen as the principle of *all* life-activity [46] in the human. The soul is then one with the life-principle, and this in turn is the ideal principle of unity by which the organism exists as a totality, as a unity that asserts itself in its relation to the external and to its organs and functions in their multiplicity. We do not, then, conceive the soul as something foreign that is, as it were, an inhabitant of the body, or as something immaterial that in an incomprehensible way governs the elements of matter in the body; but we conceive it as the real organism's *own* ideality, and we do not posit its ideality as synonymous with an absolute opposition to the material, but as the form of unity's being *as* unity in the real manifold, which, precisely by being able to become a member of a totality, of a living whole that is present *as such* in its *single*

members, shows that it bears within itself the possibility of ideality.

But when, in the concept “psychic life”, we include both fundamental forms of life as in a higher unity, it is implied that our conscious and our unconscious life must stand in a thoroughgoing reciprocal relation to one another throughout the whole series of the phenomena of individual mental life; and this thoroughgoing reciprocal relation, through which the essential unity everywhere asserts itself, we shall now try to demonstrate in brief strokes, leaving the sphere of abstract conceptual determinations in order to pass over to that of the facts.

2.

As the first activity of the life-principle that, as the principle of both forms of life, was determined as a *psychic* principle, we find the *organizing* activity. As producing an organic totality, not a heaping together of atoms, this activity shows itself to be an ideal, psychic activity, but one that is wholly in the form of the unconscious. It is the presupposition of conscious mental life, in that it develops the organs by which the reality of the life of consciousness is conditioned. But it is not merely the temporal presupposition of the life of consciousness; it is also, after that life has come to reality, the abiding condition of it, in that it constantly reproduces the organs of the life of [47] consciousness.

To this organ-forming, purely unconscious psychic activity there are then joined, by imperceptible, continuous transitions, the most elementary forms of the life of consciousness in the fetus and in the independent individual at its first stage of life. We here take the concept of the life of consciousness in its widest meaning, in which it comprises not only the stage at which the I clearly distinguishes itself as I from what is not the I, but also the stage at which consciousness still only dawns beneath sensation. From the unconscious reflex movements, through the dimmest forms of organic sensations and sense-sensations, with their mechanical pressing forward and pressing back, and on to the conscious sensations, and again from these to the more and more unfolded functions of consciousness, representation and thought, we have a series in which the transition takes place through the infinitely small, and where the boundary of qualitative differences cannot be drawn by way of experience. At every point in the advancing series there is a relatively unconscious and a relatively conscious: the unconscious beginning strives toward the conscious, and the conscious keeps the unconscious within itself as a remainder or as an element.

How the life of consciousness that develops in this way out of the unconscious preserves its indissoluble connection with it can be made clear from many different

standpoints. Thus we see that not merely by chance, but normally and periodically, *an alternation* takes place between a state in which our consciousness is awake and a state in which our psychic life is sunk down into the unconscious. In dreamless sleep, the normal form of sleep, this periodic return of our total life of consciousness into the unconscious takes place in such a way that the return shows itself to be unconditionally necessary, overwhelming every resistance of the will. And the very health of the life of consciousness, its composure and its clarity, is conditioned by this periodic immersion in the strengthening bath of the unconscious.

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We see the same reciprocal relation in the phenomenon *that every determinate content of consciousness goes back into the unconscious and comes forth from it again*. What fills consciousness at any given moment cannot abidingly be its content; every attempt to hold the particular fast in consciousness beyond a certain limit of time will inevitably fail; it is, as it were, forcibly pushed away from there. And that it must be so lies in the nature of the matter: the particular, precisely as particular, is incongruent with the generality of consciousness, which comprises everything particular; consciousness therefore cannot be pressed into its narrow limits. But what is drawn away from the focal point of consciousness, and soon moved entirely out of its field of view, is not lost to consciousness. It goes back into the unconscious depth and is kept there as the property of spirit. And it is not merely kept, so that under certain conditions it can again be lifted up to the light and remembered, but it is drawn into a process that takes place in the self beneath the level of consciousness: it enters into combinations with the rest of what is preserved, is fused together with it, and is thereby nuanced. Work goes on uninterruptedly in secret, and a development can take place that surprises us when its results come forth before consciousness, as when during sleep a thought has ripened, a decision become clear, or when during a longer period of spiritual rest a process of spiritual assimilation has taken place, the scattered and foreign material gathered and appropriated. This activity in the unconscious depth of the soul constantly sends fine effects up even to the highest and freest activities of thought and will, and the conscious spirit has no power to interrupt the work and the development that go on ceaselessly in the seemingly motionless unconscious inwardness.

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From a new standpoint we see the essential connection between the two forms of life when we observe *the mobility of the boundary between them*. Thus, for example, a movement, an action, which, when it is unfamiliar to the individual, is performed only by fixing attention on the particular parts of the organs that contribute to its performance, comes through habit to be performed unconsciously, in a mechanical way (for example,

the handling of an instrument). Only the general image of the result, and even that ever more obscured, stands before consciousness: all the steps through which the result is brought about become unconscious to us. Within certain limits this last holds of every voluntary, and as such conscious, movement. The final form of the movement stands before consciousness as an image of movement; but the intermediate links by which the movement is realized, the nerve actions and muscle contractions that are its conditions, are unconscious to us. Conversely, what in the normal state of our organism is withdrawn from consciousness can, under abnormal conditions, become conscious to us: the boundary, that is, is moved in the opposite direction.

If we analyze *the single act of consciousness*, we again find the conscious and the unconscious going together in unity, in that the act of consciousness itself is a unity of unconscious elements. If we choose, for example, the single conscious sensing, this is easily shown. The single sensation of a tone, for example, which for our immediate apprehension stands as something purely single, has as its presuppositions a physical and an organic process in which the elements are easy to point out. In the physical stimulus that conditions the determinate sensation of a tone there is a number of waves corresponding to the distinctive character of the tone, and in each of these waves, as it advances, countless degrees of condensation. And in the organic process that is called forth by that stimulus there must be something corresponding to the stimulus's elements and differences of degree. But as the organic process is converted into the psychic one, into the conscious sense-*sensation*, the manifold is gathered up into a unity in which the elements do not become conscious as such, but make themselves felt only through the qualitative determinateness of the sensation. What holds of the single sense holds of all, insofar as processes of motion are the physical and organic conditions of the various sensations. In higher forms of the life of consciousness we again meet the same [50] relation. When we form a general representation, e.g. of a tree or of an animal, we form it involuntarily, by a mechanical process in which the individual sense-images become the elements, which produce a pronounced image where they, as it were, cover one another, but are blurred where they differ. But this process, which is the presupposition of the conscious bringing-out of concepts, remains, together with its elements, in the unconscious; only the result comes before consciousness. It is this relation between the individual act of consciousness and its unconscious elements to which *Leibnitz* first drew attention. In the roar of the sea, which we perceive as a single sound, he pointed to the sound of the countless individual waves, which, without becoming conscious to us, gather into a unity for our ear; in our perception of the color green, which arises from the

mixing of finely ground blue and yellow, he pointed to the infinitely small unconscious effects of the individual color-elements in the mixture. In general, he pointed to the infinitely small as the unconscious element in every determinate conscious magnitude.

This very relation between the element and the summed unity of the elements points in turn to a new standpoint for the relation between the unconscious and the conscious. What remains unconscious for us owing to its quantitative determinateness can be raised to consciousness in a twofold way. The physical stimulus that calls forth a movement in the organism — which we cannot conceive as separate from a psychic act: an element of sensation — but not a movement strong enough to call forth a *conscious* sensation, can by *an increase in strength* release one. The same can, within certain limits, be reached by another route: through a directing of *attention*. We concentrate ourselves consciously in the particular direction, and the impression that was before too weak to be noticed, a fleeting auditory impression, for example, is now perceived clearly and consciously.

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Finally, we see the connection between the unconscious and the conscious mental life from the standpoint that a *constant reciprocal influence* takes place, through which the essential unity reveals itself. And through this we see a *circuit* brought about. What is, as it were, deposited from the sphere of conscious life into that of the unconscious and determines the latter, partly with visible effects in the organic, works back from there in turn upon the life of consciousness through the unconscious activity of the undivided, concentrated psychic-spiritual unity. From this concentrated unity, which takes up the results of the life of consciousness, the general direction of the activities of spirit is unconsciously determined, and from it there issue, in an involuntary manner, impulses to peculiar combinations of representations (associations of ideas) and supplements and correctives for cognition and will. And from that unconscious, to which the moments of the life of consciousness, as they step out of the sphere of consciousness, make their contribution, and in which they are worked together, there takes place not only, under these forms, an incessant *working-back* upon the conscious; but already *as the presupposition and foundation of the life of consciousness* the unconscious life works from the very first upon the conscious, through the moods and feelings, desires and promptings of drive grounded in its individual peculiarity, and in a special way through the connection into which it brings conscious life with the currents of universal life, with which it stands in closer and more intimate union. On the continued assimilation through the process of the unconscious depends the development of conscious life; on the normal movement of this process, the health and undisturbed harmony of the life of consciousness.

Thus we are everywhere directed to the unity of the two forms of life, to their inner connection of essence. At every stage of development they point to each other: the unconscious to the conscious as its goal, its completion and its unity; the conscious to the unconscious as its presupposition, its abiding condition, its element. Different in scope — since the life of consciousness rests on the broader base of unconscious life, so that our I, although it designates our *whole* being in its real and ideal aspect, nevertheless [52] expresses our total individual living only in the form of relative abstraction — they are one in essence, forms of the activity of the same psychic principle.

3.

When in the foregoing we considered the relation of the two forms of life, we saw it solely from the standpoint of individual life and as pointing back to the relation between the side of nature and the side of spirit in us. But the relation will appear in a new and clearer light when the standpoint is widened from the individual to the universal active in the individual, and when we see the reciprocal relation between the conscious and the unconscious as conditioned by the relation of the individual *spirit* to a more universal *spiritual* power.

We already arrive at this relation by going back to the concept of the concentrated unity of the self, which makes itself felt in an immediate way in the individual's conscious life. For in this concentrated unity we can distinguish between the *acquired*, which, as assimilated, has entered into the unity in the form of immediate being, and the *original*, which is given as an endowment of essence and from the beginning works unconsciously; and this originally unconscious working we now seek precisely in the *highest spiritual* functions: in the working of the *a priori* and in *genius*, since in the one as in the other we see something universal making itself felt through what belongs most inwardly to individuality.

What we, with a name accepted in philosophy, call the *a priori* designates the original forms in which the peculiar character of our spiritual essence gives itself expression throughout all its activity in the various directions of the life of spirit, and gives itself expression in such a way that these forms show themselves as laid down, prior to the influence, in the essence that is determined to activity by the influence. In every domain of the human spirit where a peculiar activity of consciousness appears, a peculiarly pronounced *a priori* must make itself felt: in our intuiting, in our thinking, in our ethical [53] acting and our artistic producing. But this *a priori*, which expresses the fundamental peculiarity of our essence, points back — since this essence is not through itself but is grounded in something higher — to that higher: the fundamental source of existence;

and it becomes — since what is the ground of our essence must be of one essence with what is grounded — an expression (if an abstract expression) of the essence of the principle of existence itself. This a priori, which is a determination of essence in us, comes to be for consciousness — precisely as a determination of essence in *spirit*, which by virtue of its freedom is *itself* to *acquire* what is originally *given* to it — only through an activity of spirit: it must come to be for consciousness through our own energy, merely incited by experience. But before it comes to consciousness, it works normatively and determiningly in every act of consciousness; by its hidden working it prepares the possibility of the doubling of consciousness by which it can itself become an object for consciousness, and in the very act by which it comes forth before consciousness it is itself, as normative for *every* act of spirit, unconsciously determining. It is the law of our essence that determines the act by which the basic forms of the active essence are first to be raised to consciousness. But these forms of the essence are at the same time forms of something higher, expressions of the essence of the universal principle, and thereby valid not only for the individual self but for humanity and for existence.

What holds of the a priori in general holds by the same token of the pregnant form of it that comes forth in *genius*. In genius there is an original possibility in the form of the unconscious, which works irresistibly toward a revelation in consciousness; but even when the genius becomes most clearly conscious of itself, something unconscious is nonetheless preserved in the working of genius. The unity of necessity and freedom, of the working of nature and the energy of spirit, that characterizes the genius while it instinctively seeks revelation, characterizes it still in its highest development of consciousness. Its highest working is in the form of immediacy, an unconscious creating, [54] which only when it has given its work reality radiates through that work the light in which it itself becomes partly transparent. And in the producing of genius — in which the individual stamps its spiritual peculiarity in the most intensive way — the individual feels itself to be the organ of a higher power by which it is pervaded. The deed of genius has the validity of the idea; but thereby it points back to the ideal power from which the gift of genius has its source.

By what is most original and deepest in the working of the individual spirit we are thus led back to *the working of the universal in the individual*, and here the relation between the conscious and the unconscious in us then appears in a peculiar light. The working of the universal, although a spiritual working, becomes in relation to the individual something partially or totally unconscious, both because the universal is the comprehensive, the overarching, which is not contained in the individual spirit, whose relation to it is the

relation of the single member of the totality to the totality itself and its principle, — and because the forms of activity of the universal are not congruent with the forms of activity of finite consciousness. Even when the individual spirit becomes most clearly conscious of its relation to the pervading universal, the unconscious working is converted into consciousness only within a certain limit, because this very act is unconsciously steered and determined by what works more deeply, just as the act by which the a priori was made an object of consciousness was determined by the very working of the a priori, unconscious to the individual.

The middle term through which the unconscious influence of the principle of existence upon the individual life of consciousness is realized is *the real whole of existence*. This, as a totality determined by the principle, is in its real being the rationally determined, the planned (teleological); but it is the *unconsciously* rational, the *unconsciously* thinking, the *unconsciously* purposive. The unconscious reason of nature is the foundation of the conscious, individual life of reason. We think only inasmuch as we have a brain that has been formed by the unconscious thought of nature into the organ of our thought. Behind [55] our conscious thought lies “that which thinks in us”; and the involuntary, unconscious production of thought proceeding from the essence, from the “genius of thought”, what we might call “inner thinking”, “thought in and for itself”, lies behind the consciousness of this thinking, behind the presentation of thought, not only to others but to ourselves.

In *historical development* the reciprocal relation between the conscious and the unconscious appears in pregnant forms. Since historical development is a teleological development, and since in such a development the goal of development is at every stage *ideally* present in its wholeness as that which determines and guides the development, the steering and guiding power of development is present as that which reaches beyond the individual consciousness, and whose content is realized for consciousness only in a limited form. In its wholeness it is therefore something unconsciously working: it works behind consciousness, hidden from consciousness. Therefore it works as the individual’s *fate*, which can indeed be illuminated by consciousness, but only partially, since the principle of thought becomes an object for thought according to a *single* determinateness, a *single* basic relation, or only in an *abstract* way. The principle of historical development, in its working as a concrete totality, preserves, as that which pervades the consciousness of the individual, its stamp of a fate that is only relatively explained as a conscious law of spirit. The universal principle of spirit, at every moment, unconsciously for the individual, gathers the individual consciousness together under its overarching necessity.

From one further standpoint the relation of conscious mental life to unconscious mental life shows itself to us, when we see *death* as the return of the total life of consciousness into the unconscious. Since our life of consciousness in all its forms is throughout organically conditioned, the dissolution of the organism must necessarily entail the cessation of all these forms of consciousness, and the nearest expression for [56] this becomes: a return into the unconscious. But this expression can conceal a double meaning. It can designate a dissolution of the self into the material elements whose forces worked together in the living individual. That would be materialism's interpretation of the expression. But it can also designate a return into a, as it were, more deepened and more inwardized form of being, for which the determinations of the life of consciousness no longer have validity. And we are directed back to such an interpretation by the fact that the freedom of the human spirit includes the guarantee of its eternity, secures it against being able to vanish as something without essence; but that the same freedom points back to the divine as its source, to self-surrender to the principle, to union of essence with it as the highest goal, and precisely thereby points beyond the sphere in which the life of consciousness, with its relativity and finite oppositions, has a place. But when we then ask about the form of the being of spiritual life after the life of consciousness has vanished along with its conditions, we raise a question which, precisely because in our thinking we are bound to the forms of the life of consciousness, can be answered by us only through hints and analogies. We then seek an analogy in a relation that was touched on in the foregoing: in the relation of the individual act of consciousness to the total unconscious mental life and to the whole of the life of consciousness. When the individual content of consciousness that has been called forth by an external influence, a sense-image, for example, steps away from the horizon of consciousness and goes back into the unconscious, it enters through the latter into a comprehensive connection of memories and thoughts; it is appropriated by this connection, transformed, inwardized from sense-image into representation and thought, and as such belongs to our comprehensive spiritual unity of life. In this inwardization through the return into the unconscious we might seek an analogy that can suggest the form of the transformation of the individual self at the cessation of the life of consciousness. Its going back into the unconscious would then be one with a transformation from the form of phenomenal, sensibly determined [57] externality to a deeper inwardness. It would then be a moment in the life of the eternal, in the unity from which the unfolding of life in existence eternally proceeds; and it would be joined together with the other individual spirits in the organization of the eternal fullness of life. That analogy can also be extended to the relation between individual spirits. Just

as our individual acts of consciousness, in their conscious separation from one another, have a continuity *beneath the boundary line of consciousness* and are therefore gathered in the comprehensive, uniting unity of spirit, so the individual spirits, whose organisms are indeed members of one comprehensive physical totality, can be conceived as joined together in their unconscious ground by one that bears, embraces and connects them, and as going back, [in] death, to this ground, and in it to a deeper, more inward union.

Thus the life of consciousness would then become like a region in our psychic life that was bounded on both sides by the unconscious. It rises up out of the ground of unconscious *organic* living; it is, during the development of human life, at every moment borne and conditioned by the unconscious, in constant reciprocal action with it; and as it reaches its close, it goes back into an unconscious that now expresses a higher *spiritual* form of life, raised above the limitation of the life of consciousness, above its separation of externality and its finitude: a life in unity with the divine, which in its eternal knowledge of itself is not, like the conscious self, limited by something alien, but in this knowledge includes the whole of existence, and includes it not as what is merely reflected, but as that which has being only through the essence that in its knowledge embraces it.

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